SOREN BANKS ON SYMPATHY

THE RULING COMBINE IS HOPING THE FORMER CM'S ARREST TRIGGERS A TRIBAL BACKLASH AGAINST THE BJP, WHICH IN TURN IS TRYING TO PAINT THE ED ACTION AS EVIDENCE OF THEIR CORRUPTION

BY AMITABH SRIVASTAVA



"**You know from whom we need to save the country**... JMM [Jharkhand Mukti Morcha], Congress *aur* INDI *gathbandhan* [INDIA alliance] *ke jo karname hain*.... JMM *aur* Congress *ke thikanon se jo noton ke bandal nikal rahe hain... yahan mantri, mantri ka PA, PA ka bhi naukar* [the deeds of the Congress-JMM and INDIA coalition, the bundles of notes that are being recovered from JMM-Congress hideouts... here minister, the personal assistant of the minister and the personal assistant's servant]...." Prime Minister Narendra [paused significantly as he left the sentence hanging during his address at a rally on May 11 in Jharkhand's Chatra district. "*Maine to kabhi apni aankhon se itne note nahin dekhe* [I have never seen so much money]," he went on to say, as the audience cheered lustily at his statement.

The PM was alluding to the more than Rs 32 crore worth of "unaccounted-for" cash the Enforcement Directorate (ED) had allegedly recovered on May 6 from a flat linked to Jahangir Alam, the domestic help of Jharkhand officer Sanjeev Lal. Lal himself is the personal secretary of the state's rural development minister, Alamgir Alam. While Lal and his domestic help were the first to be taken into custody, the ED arrested Alamgir on May 15 after two days of questioning in what it alleges is a money-laundering case. The minister has denied that the money recovered by the ED belonged to him.

The alleged "rising corruption" in Jharkhand under the JMM-Congress-Rashtriya Janata Dal (RJD) government that has been in power in the state since 2019 has been the central narrative of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) during its campaigns in the state for the ongoing Lok Sabha election. In another rally in Singhbhum earlier in the month, the prime minister had accused the Congress and the JMM of being in a "race of corruption and looting". BJP leaders in the state have also cited former chief minister Hemant Soren's arrest in January in an alleged land scam as an example of corruption in the state government.

Jharkhand votes for the Lok Sabha in the fourth, fifth, sixth and seventh phases, on May 13, 20, 25 and June 1, respectively. Khunti, Singhbhum and Lohardaga, three seats that are reserved for candidates from the Scheduled Tribes (ST) were among the constituencies that went to the polls on May 13, with the state recording an approximate voter turnout of 65.2 per cent. While the BJP had won the Khunti and Lohardaga seats in the previous general election in 2019, Singhbhum had gone to the Congress. The saffron party had won 11 of the 14 Lok Sabha seats in the state, while ally All Jharkhand Students Union (AJSU) had netted one. On the Opposition side, the Congress and the JMM won a seat each. This year, the BJP is contesting 13 seats, leaving one for alliance partner AJSU. Of the partners in the Indian National Developmental Inclusive Alliance (INDIA), the Congress is contesting seven Lok Sabha seats, the JMM five seats, and the RJD and CPI-ML one each.

Political observers are not sure